NEITHER JOHN KENNEDY NOR HIS ADVISERS IMAGINED AT the time that dropping pyrotechnic devices on submarines could be as dangerous as releasing depth charges. But pyrotechnic devices were Vice President Lyndon Johnson's prime concern at the ExCom meeting on the afternoon of October 27, just as the B-59 drama was unfolding in the Caribbean. "I have been afraid of those damned flares ever since they mentioned them," he told the ExCom members who were discussing the possibility of night surveillance flights over Cuba. "Imagine some crazy Russian captain doing it. The damn thing goes 'blooey' and lights up the skies. He might just pull a trigger. Looks like we are playing Fourth of July over there or something." Johnson drew on his political experience: "Psychologically you scare them. Well, hell, it's always like the fellow telling me in Congress, 'Go on and put the monkey on his back.' Every time I tried to put a monkey on somebody else's back, I got one. If you are going to try to psychologically scare them with flares, you're liable to get your bottom shot at."[20]

Johnson's view prevailed, and the proposed surveillance flights over Cuba were not authorized. He had no idea that at the time he intervened in the debate a proverbial monkey on the back of Captain Savitsky almost caused him to fire a nuclear torpedo at the American "bottom." Triggered by unintended consequences of air photography in the night skies over the Caribbean and stopped from further escalation by a stuck searchlight in the silo of the Soviet submarine, the most dangerous episode of the sea hunt faded away almost as soon as it occurred.

It was Slaughter's searchlight and the message he was transmitting that saved the situation. But that required a stroke of good luck. Savitsky descended from the bridge and gave his order to prepare the nuclear torpedo immediately after a US Navy plane dropped flares above the submarine. The others, including the communications officer with a searchlight and Arkhipov, began to descend as well, but, as Leonenko recalled, "coming down, the signals officer got stuck with his searchlight in the shaft of the upper hatch of the conning tower, thereby delaying the commander." Arkhipov, who remained on the bridge, noticed Slaughter's searchlight and read the message. It was an apology. As Leonenko recalled, Arkhipov, realizing that the "American frigate had begun signaling us by searchlight